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HEALTHCARE INFORMATICS
https://www.sqlrv.com

Leadership Essentials for Data Teams

Just who is this guy?

Principal Data Architect, Population Health

Adjunct Instructor

Ambassador Programs

Speaker – various events

B.S. Computer Science

M.S. Computer Information Systems

M.S. Health Informatics

Doctor of Healthcare Administration

40 Years

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Something to consider…

credit

"Leadership is all about people. It is not about organizations. It is not about plans. It is not about strategies. It is about people – motivating people to get the job done. You have to be people-centered."

– Colin Powell (1937 – 2021) U.S. Army General and former U.S. Secretary of State

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Introduction

- Data Team Leadership
  - Team Leader to Director, and everything in between
  - Legacy Data Migrations
  - Architecting/Building New Systems
  - Expanding/Supporting Existing Systems
- Team Environments
  - Onsite with FTEs & Contractors
  - Onsite blended with remote (onshore & offshore)
  - Fully Remote (onshore & offshore)

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Agenda

- Principles of Leadership
  - Attributes of a Leader
  - Team Motivation
  - Conflict Resolution
  - Fostering Growth and Cohesion
- Data Team Leadership
  - Challenging Requirements
  - Team Diversity (Skills/Geography/Aptitude/Attitude)
  - Standards & Documentation
- Wrap-up

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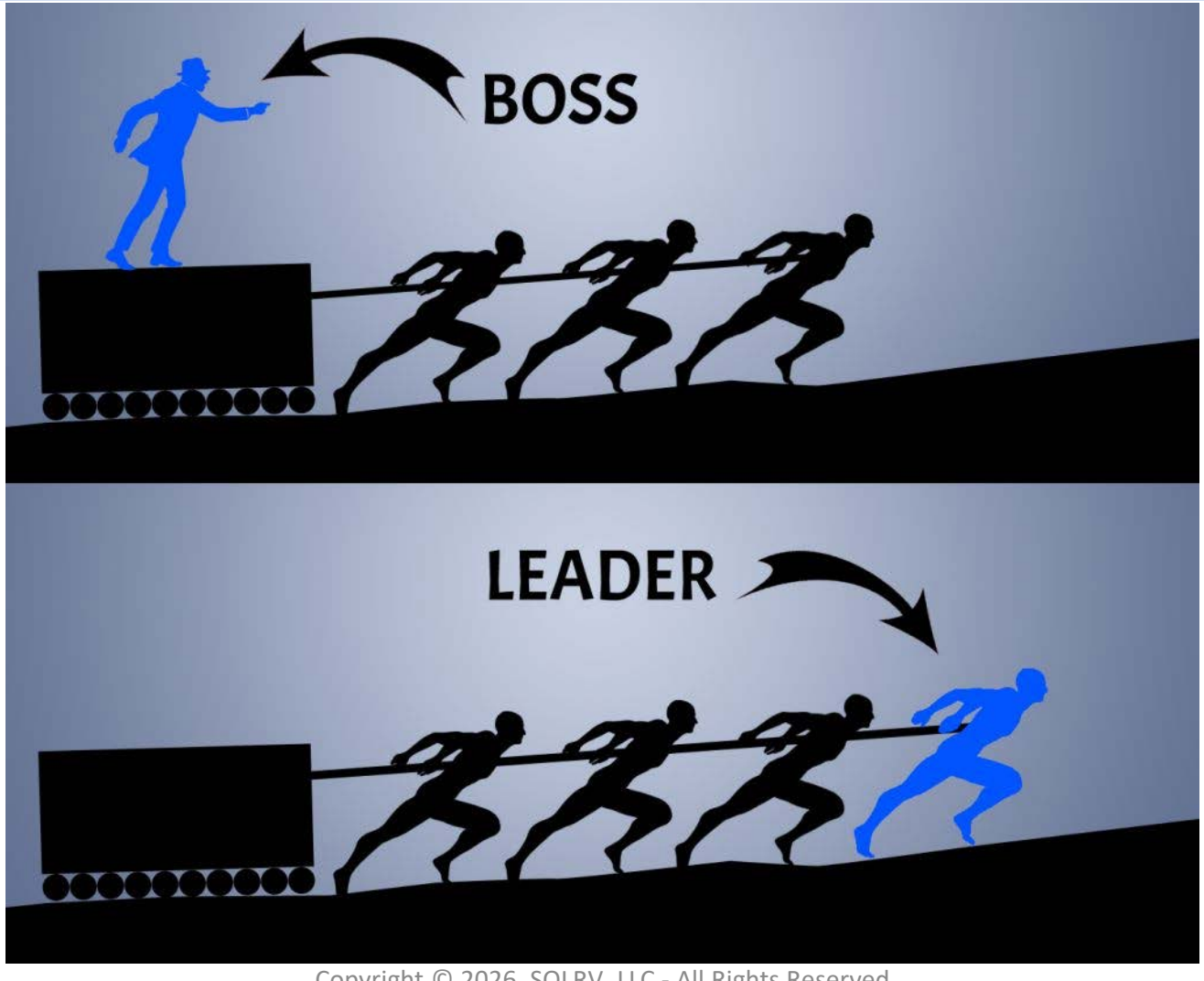
Principles of Leadership



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Principles of Leadership

- Leader: A person who guides, inspires, and motivates a group towards achieving a common goal.
- Do not confuse the attributes of a leader with the title of a leader
  - Not all leaders have the title
  - Not all who have the title are a leader
  - Many are leaders by *who* they are, not *what* they are
- Leader: one who inspires others to follow through trust
- *SQL Team Six: How to Build Effective Teams*

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Principles of Leadership

- Sun Tzu identified 5 principles of leadership in *The Art of War*:
  - Unity of Purpose (Goals, Vision, Cohesion)
  - Building Loyalty (Authority, Trust, Respect)
  - Strategic Foresight (Planning, Preparation, Empowerment)
  - Adaptability (Analysis, Flexibility, Understanding)
  - Virtuous Leadership (Integrity, Compassion, Morale)
- These principles identify the attributes of a leader
- Many attributes build upon one another

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Principles of Leadership

Principles of Leadership

- Attributes of a leader are intrinsically personal
- Team motivation is not just a rousing speech
- What you do as a leader
  - Authority – Either granted by position or earned by ability
  - Goals – Organizationally directed or personally derived
  - Vision – How well your plans are communicated to others
  - Analysis – Determining the current and future states
  - Planning – To achieve the goals and arrive at the vision
  - Preparation – Anticipating both successes and failures

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Principles of Leadership

- Who you are as a person
  - Integrity – Primary ingredient of a person's character
  - Compassion – The first step in working with others
  - Understanding – Not just project needs, people's needs too
  - Respect – For every person on the team
  - Trust – Trust your team and they will trust you
  - Flexibility – Required with projects as well as people
  - Empowerment – More than mere delegation; Give purpose
  - Cohesion – Serve as the glue to bring the team together
  - Morale – The result of all the above

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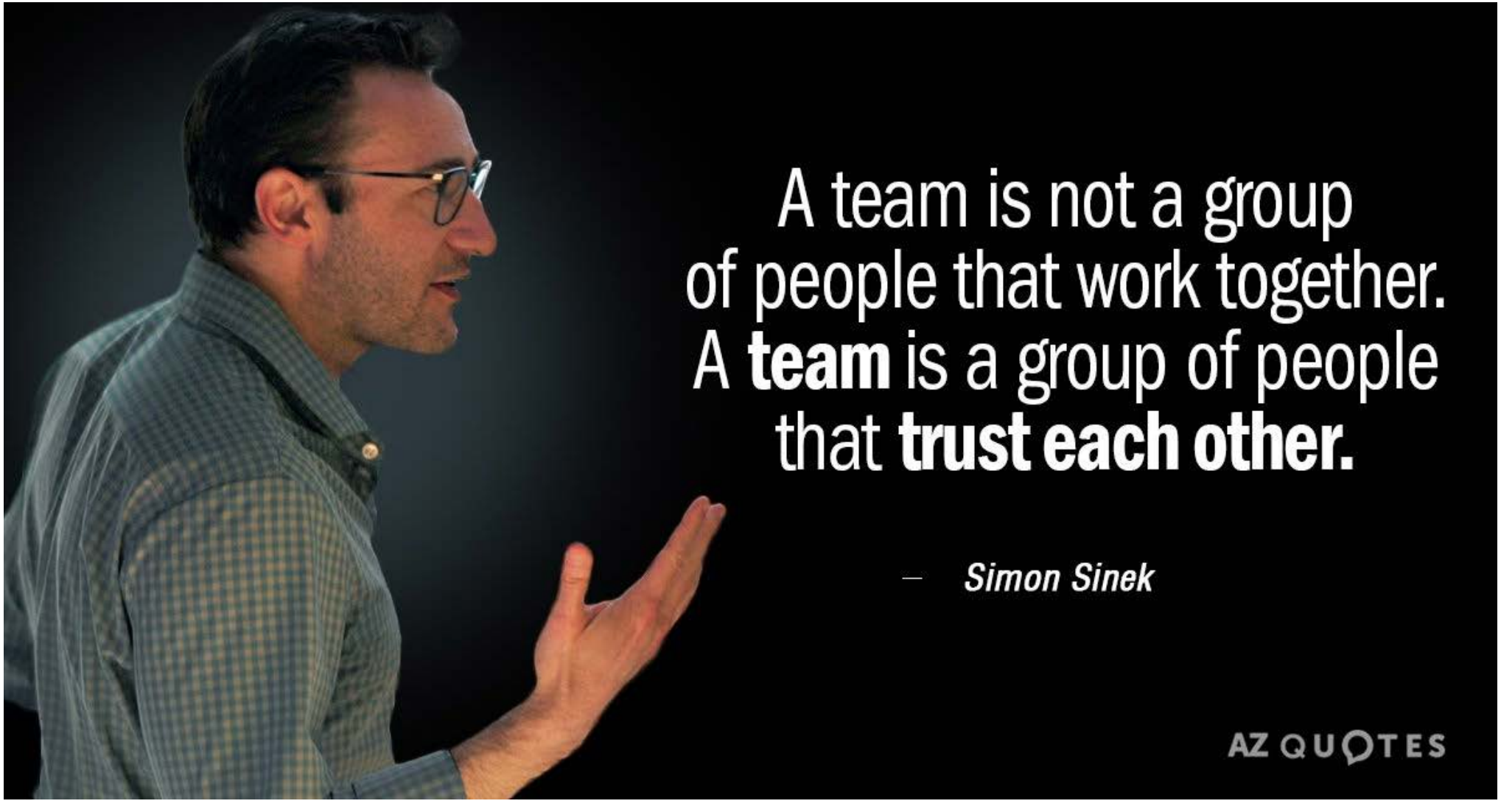
Principles of Leadership



Principles of Leadership

- Teamwork is not just between the leader and each individual person on the team
  - The team needs to trust and have faith in each other
  - While the spokes of a wheel connect to the hub, they each depend upon one another to function properly
- Trust your team:
  - Explain what needs to be accomplished and when
  - Let them determine *HOW* it should be done
  - Let them lead discussions and express themselves freely
  - Everyone participates and listens to each other

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Principles of Leadership

- Earn your team's trust:
  - What you say, show, and act should be *consistent*
  - Your behaviors and reactions should be *predictable*
  - Explain what is going on and why for full *transparency*
  - Everything you say and do should exhibit *honesty*
  - In all circumstances, your character should represent *integrity*
- To be motivated, a team needs trust and faith in:
  - Themselves
  - Each other
  - Their leader

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Principles of Leadership

Principles of Leadership

- When people are involved, conflict is inevitable
- Immediate steps for conflict resolution
  - Listen to both sides – objectivity is critical
  - Focus on behavior – avoid personality judgments
  - Establish ground rules – no personal attacks; equal time
  - Guide to a solution – encourage a brainstorm solution
  - Take breaks if needed – to cool highly emotional reactions
- Hold regular one-on-one sessions with team members
  - Each needs to feel valued and appreciated
  - Each needs to be heard and understood

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Principles of Leadership

- Conflict prevention is better than resolution
- Foster a culture of inclusion and safety
  - Encourage psychological safety
  - Promote open communication
  - Set clear expectations
- Adapt your leadership style
  - Customize communication per individual
  - Practice empathetic leadership
  - Be adaptable and flexible

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Principles of Leadership

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Principles of Leadership

- Build genuine connections and shared ownership
  - Invest in team relationships to each other
  - Hold regular team meetings as well as 1-on-1 sessions
  - Have team members conduct meeting and rotate the role
- Drive accountability with autonomy
  - A leader cannot address all issues effectively
  - Allow for some flexibility in how members achieve goals
  - Give each member an opportunity to lead in some way
  - Allow room for healthy discussion and structure for debate

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Principles of Leadership

- Encouraging autonomy leads to growth and cohesion
- Encourage continuous learning & growth plans
  - Training opportunities – Individually and collectively
  - Mentorship – Pair new/inexperienced members with seasoned ones
  - Cross training – Role shadowing and rotations
- Build team cohesion
  - Foster open communication
  - Team building activities
  - Recognize individual and team achievements

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Principles of Leadership

Remember, a team leader is nothing without the team.

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Principles of Leadership – Recap

- Leadership is not just what you do as a leader but more about who you are as a person.
- Relationships between team members are just as critical as between each team member and the leader.
- Trust is the foundation of a team, and the leader can make or break that trust.
- A leader can resolve conflicts with civility and effective communication as an objective mediator.
- An investment in your team will pay strong dividends!

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Questions?

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Data Team Leadership

What management is anticipating…

What the Agile team delivered.

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Data Team Leadership

- Consists of all the challenges of leadership plus a few more unique situations
  - Requirements (Conflicting/Unclear/Incomplete/ Inconsistent/Missing)
  - Team Diversity (Skills/Geography/Aptitude/Attitude)
  - Standards and Documentation (or the lack thereof)
  - Data Quality (Mostly during ingestion but also reporting)
  - Long-Term Planning
- Of course, other situations too (but time is limited)

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Data Team Leadership

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Data Team Leadership

- Like it or not, requirements will be your responsibility!
  - Management tends to assume things are well understood
  - Ask questions until you have the answers you need
  - Document everything and reference it in every meeting
- Confirm details and priorities
  - When management doesn’t understand, they think its easy
  - Many assumptions DO NOT get discussed and incorporated
  - Mental images of the final result DO NOT get clarified
    - Create an overall process flow for all major steps
    - If possible, create a mock-up or visual of the expected result

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Data Team Leadership

- Ongoing strategies to keep projects on scope:
  - Transparent communication for all stakeholders
    - Most focus on completed milestones
    - Identify critical points on the overall timeline and deliveries
    - Also discuss gaps, missing requirements, and potential risks
  - Document all risks and scope changes
    - Scope creep, requirement clarifications, and schedule changes
    - Don’t forget personnel changes, PTOs, and critical points
  - Hold regular meetings and press for feedback
  - Focus on iterative development within an established plan

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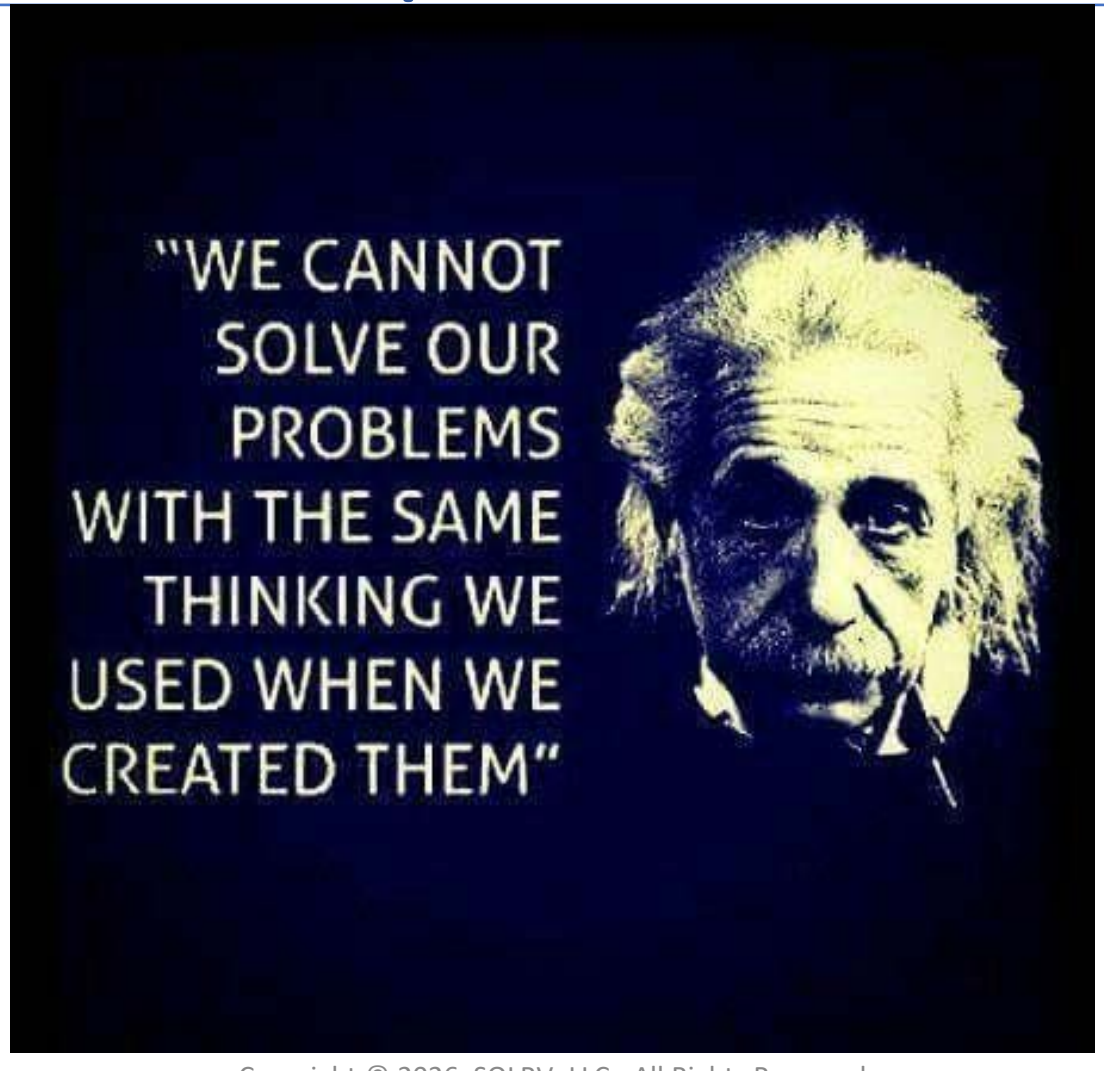
Data Team Leadership



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Data Team Leadership

- Team Diversity creates opportunity as well as challenge
- Geography (onsite/remote, onshore/offshore)
  - Challenges in maintaining focus and drive
  - Time zones, meetings, working hours, and deadlines
- Skills (roles, levels, assignments, and preferences)
- Personal diversity
  - Aptitude – Natural ability/talent to learn a skill
  - Attitude – Mental stance or outlook

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Data Team Leadership

- Set clear communication protocols
  - Tools (email, chat, video)
  - Rules (what to use, when, & under what circumstances)
  - Expectations (what is due, requirements, and delivery)
- Manage team cohesion
  - Ensure transparency as much as possible
  - Encourage active participation – give all a voice
  - Hold regular 1-on-1 and whole team meetings
  - Foster a sense of belonging and appreciation

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Data Team Leadership

- Manage remote team members effectively
  - Be mindful of local holidays and customs
  - Encourage cross-cultural collaboration
  - Set primary time zone for all meetings at company HQ
  - Set group meetings (standups, etc.) during common hours
  - Be aware of proximity bias
- Break Team into Groups according to
  - Time zone proximity
  - Split skillsets across groups (dev, QA, etc.)
  - Select appropriate group leader

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Data Team Leadership

How strong is your foundation?

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Data Team Leadership

- Strong data standards = foundation of data governance
  - Define objectives and scope to determine ultimate goal
  - Assess the current data landscape
    - Determine what is captured, stored, and used
    - Identify gaps, weaknesses, and opportunities
  - Create plan to reach the goal along with other priorities
- Identify data governance stakeholders and get buy-in
  - Involve business representatives with ownership
  - Implement plans to enforce standards
- Regularly communicate status & revise accordingly

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Data Team Leadership

- Use standards to enforce data quality
  - Everyone knows its important and wants it
  - No one truly understands how to implement it
  - Everyone thinks someone else is taking care of it
- Establish data quality rules like any other standard
  - Identify what the rules should be
  - Implement means to apply the rules
  - Create processes to verify data quality
- Proactive quality is more valuable than remediation

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Data Team Leadership

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Data Team Leadership

- Time spent on proper planning is far less than time spent on corrections
  - Prioritize features according to need and feasibility
  - Plan roadmap to prepare early for future features
  - Changes made during planning is much cheaper than later
- Prevent short-term “fixes” from becoming permanent
  - Usually when doing it “right now” supersedes doing it right
  - Typically focused simply on the problem of the moment
  - Patches weaken the overall framework introducing issues
  - Often interferes with long-term solutions requiring rework

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Data Team Leadership

- But what about Agile Development?
  - Agile is great for managing the actual development process
  - Planning establishes the framework for Agile sprints
  - Ensures project stays on track without losing flexibility
  - Avoids Agile from becoming “fragile!”
- Types of advance planning
  - Feature prioritization
  - Data Architecture
  - Data Flow processes
- “Velocity without foresight usually leads to fragility.” – Grant Fritchey

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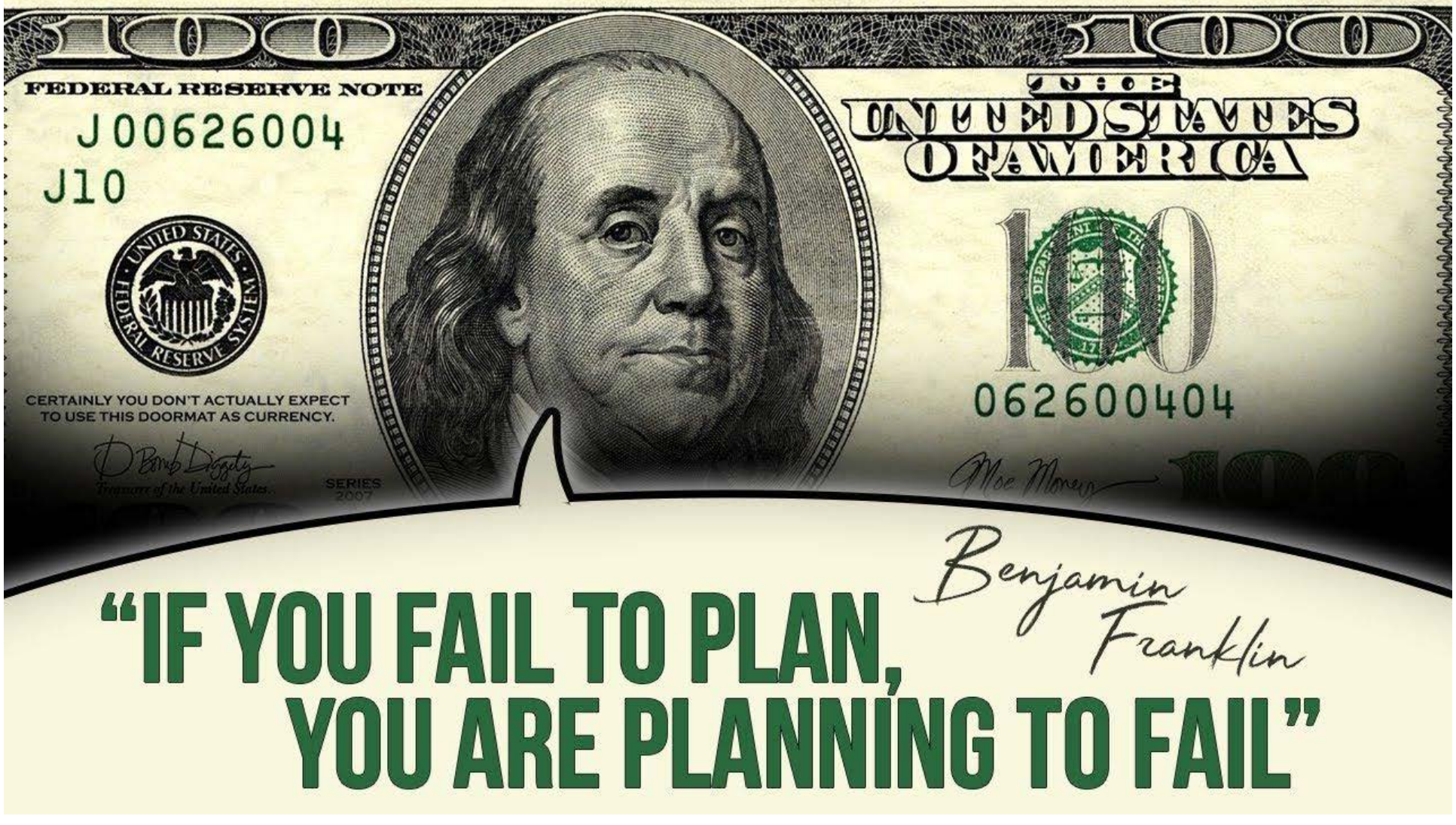
Data Team Leadership



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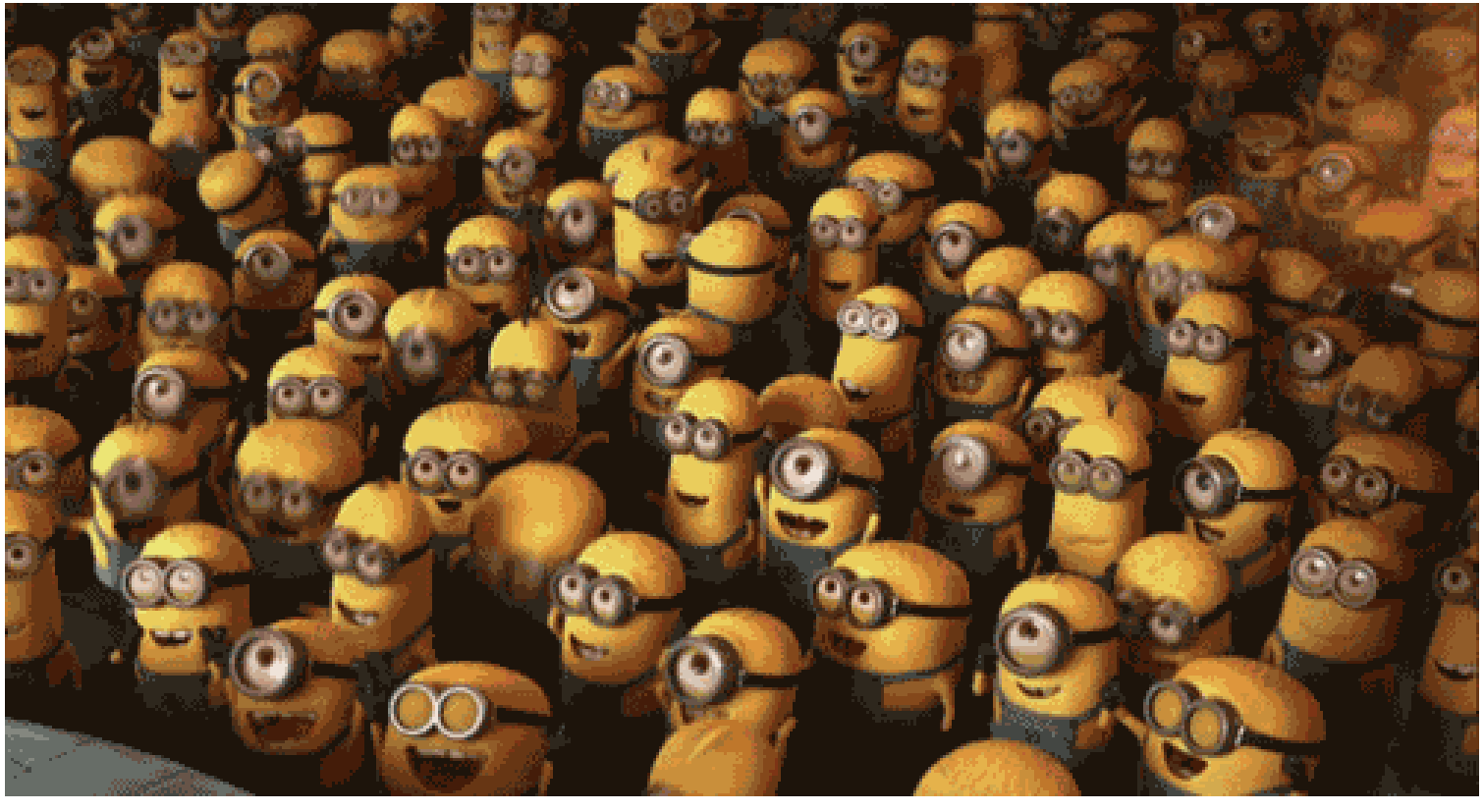

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Questions & Comments

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